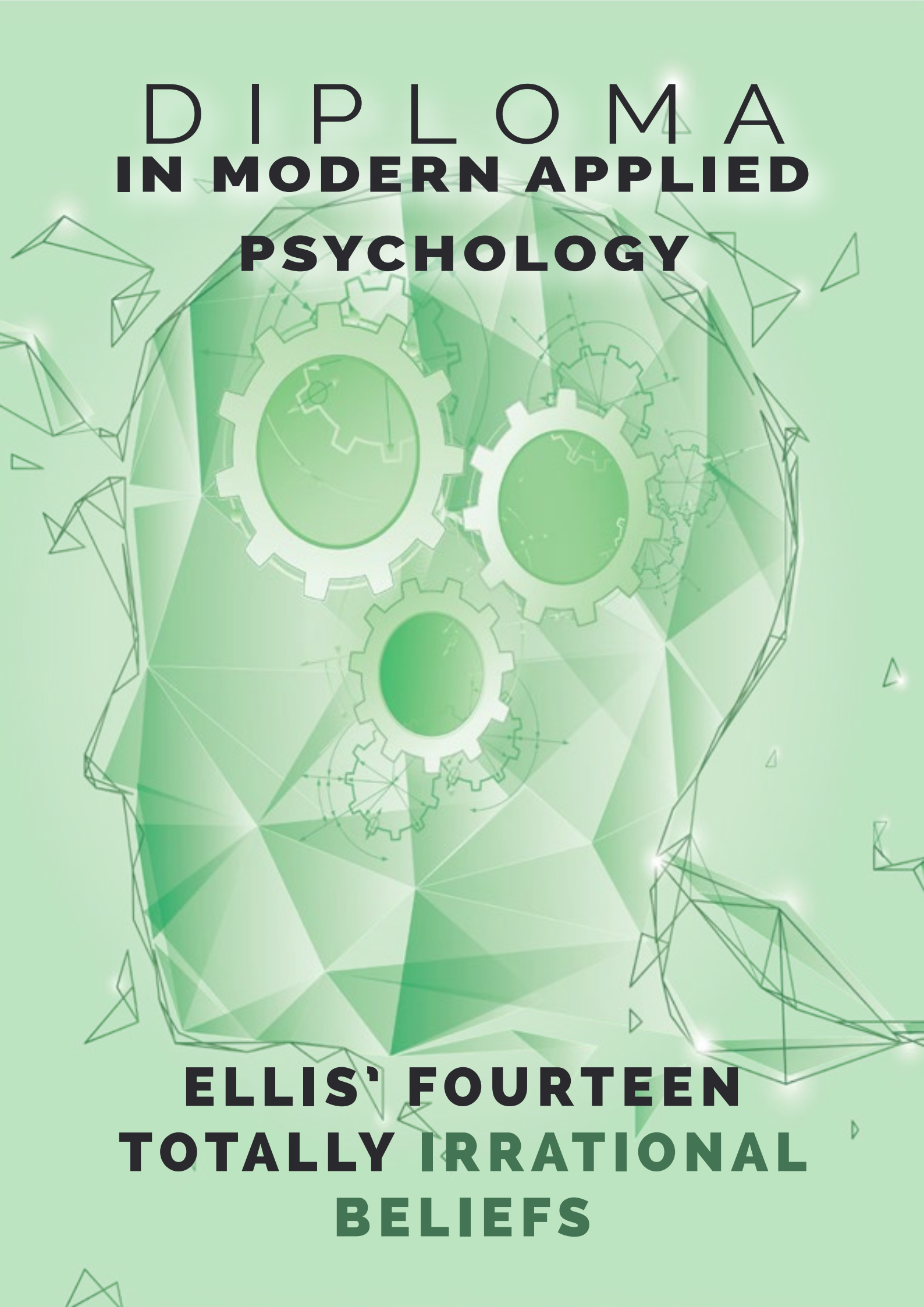


The background is a vibrant green with a complex, abstract geometric pattern. It features a large, central, faceted shape resembling a crystal or a stylized head, composed of various shades of green triangles and polygons. Overlaid on this are three interlocking gears of different sizes, rendered in a lighter green with white outlines. Thin, white lines and arrows suggest movement and interconnectedness throughout the design.

DIPLOMA IN MODERN APPLIED PSYCHOLOGY

ELLIS' FOURTEEN TOTALLY IRRATIONAL BELIEFS

ELLIS' FOURTEEN IRRATIONAL BELIEFS

Our beliefs play a huge role in how we conduct ourselves on a day to day basis. A. Ellis argued that a small number of core beliefs underlie several of our unhelpful emotions and behaviours. Core beliefs are underlying rules or code which guides how we react to the events and circumstances in our lives. Over the thirty-five years Ellis worked on this cognitive level, Ellis identified a trend that all dysfunctional behaviour and attitudes functioned out of one (or more) of these self-defeating rules.

1. I need everyone to approve of me

People pleasers are everywhere: you either know a few people pleasers or you are a people pleaser yourself. People pleasers say yes to everyone and everything, regardless as to whether or not they want to. They perpetually lie to fit into other people's narratives and demands: they agree with opinions they don't agree with, they compliment people's outfits which they don't like, they'll say things they believe other people want to hear, they'll attend social events they didn't want to go to and they'll even date people they don't even fancy for fear of 'hurting their feelings'.

Why do people compromise their own sincerity, integrity and authenticity to please other people? It's usually because they believe their opinions, needs, thoughts and whole persona isn't good enough. They usually came from backgrounds where parents, guardians or authority figures emotionally or physically abused them and rejected them, resulting in a desire in adulthood to seek any form of approval, regardless of its legitimacy. It's incredibly hard to trust people who say yes out of fear than then out of authenticity.

2. I must avoid being disliked by any source

Similarly to the first point, people who don't like to be disliked by people are people pleasers. To avoid being disliked, they'll maintain friendships with people they don't personally like (or are afraid of being on the wrong side of) or be overly friendly with people who clearly dislike them, going out of their way to buy them nice things, compliment them and strike up a conversation with them. Again, this way of being is inauthentic and deceitful, but people don't act this way out of bad intentions: they're merely trying to disprove their deep-seated belief that they are an unkind, nasty, horrible, boring person who nobody likes and who doesn't deserve friendship or love.

3. I must succeed in everything I do to be valuable

Many people are addicted to success, usually because they have a deep-seated core belief that they are a failure. Their parents or teachers may have made them feel like nothing they ever did was good enough or that they were a mistake which ruined their lives, so they spend the rest of their adult lives trying to out-work this core belief that they're a failure who will never amount to anything. As a result, they end up burned out, overworked and stressed. Rather than defining success as being true to one's values, being authentic and living with integrity, they define success as money, career status, materialism and grades.

4. It's not OK to make mistakes. If I do, I'm a bad person

Progression in life relies heavily on our ability to learn lessons from the risks we take and the mistakes we make. Unfortunately, there are millions of people who will never step outside of their comfort zone and take risks because they believe that every mistake they make defines who they are and their capabilities in life. They see mistakes not as learning opportunities, but as markers of their own incapacities and insufficiency.



ELLIS' FOURTEEN IRRATIONAL BELIEFS

5. Other people should strive to ensure I am always happy

Whilst it's easy to look at this rule and believe it only applies to a small minority of people who act like Veruca Salt, this idea isn't as clear cut as that. There's no denying that there are people in this world who feel entitled to be taken care of and appeased by everyone from strangers to immediate friends and family, there are more people out there who carry this belief more subtly. Whenever someone doesn't go out of their way to please us, like a waiter in a restaurant or a friend, we feel affronted and offended because we expected more from them.

We complain when people said something which offended us and bottle hatred towards them because they should have been more considerate, subsequently allowing their inconsideration to negatively impact our day, week or even lifetime. We can easily fall into the trap of self-consumption and forget that our needs, values and life objectives are not any more significant than those around us, so we prioritise our feelings, needs and emotional satisfaction without considering the complexity of those of the people we interact with. If you believe other people are responsible for your feelings (eg. someone else can offend you), then you're admitting that you're too irresponsible to manage your own emotions.

6. People who do not make me happy should be punished

Many people feel an urge for vengeance when they've been wronged: they hope someone who hurt them feels hurt sometime soon or they hope the person who stole from them gets robbed to see how they like it. Whilst that may be a natural inclination to feel this way in extreme circumstances, it's never a healthy way to respond and it's even healthier when this desire for vindictiveness enters our everyday realm onto those who haven't even wronged us, but merely didn't appease us.

There's an extreme level of self-importance which comes with the idea that our displeasure is worthy of trial and punishment to the source which caused it (in fact, it's somewhat reminiscent of evil kings and queens from fairytales). Your happiness and pleasure isn't the responsibility of anyone else, and it's not any more important than other people's happiness.

7. Things must work out the way I want them to

Whilst it's healthy to have grounded and positive expectations for yourself, having expectations can be deadly when too much weight is put on them. People with this mindset believe things should be the way they want things to be: their career should be x, their partner should look like x, people should give them the responses they expect from them, the food should taste exactly how they imagined it to, etc.

Because they put so much weight on how they want things to be, they fail to appreciate how things are. We would be much happier if we cut out all expectations we have of processes, people, life paths, careers, experiences and things.

8. My emotions are illnesses which I cannot control

People can easily get drawn into the idea that their mental health defines them, and that the only power they have in controlling the state of their mind is through drugs or therapy. Whilst in very severe cases drugs may be absolutely essential, and therapy is something everyone should be encouraged to take from time to time, your mental health label is not your life sentence. It doesn't define you and it doesn't limit you to be this way forever: out of all the illnesses we can have in our lifetime, it's the one we have the most power over.



ELLIS' FOURTEEN IRRATIONAL BELIEFS

Whilst drugs and therapy can help, you are the definitive power between yourself and mental wellbeing. Therapy won't do the work for you, only you can do that work, and even in cases where it's necessary when it comes to mental health, drugs can't do all the work and make it all go away either. Until we take responsibility for the part that we're playing and the power we have over our minds, we can never be the conduits of change, as we will remain disempowered and dependent upon external sources.

9. I can feel happy in life without contributing back in some way

We're all creative people in some form. Whether our creativity is artistic, linguistic, scientific or mechanical, we are all capable of producing new things. However, our beliefs are what limit our creative power. Sometimes, people live life trying to get more stuff in order to feel more fulfilled rather than produce more stuff. Unless you focus on giving back in life and giving yourself out into the world, you'll only ever seek to feed an ever-hungry consumption which will never leave you feeling happy or satisfied in the long term.

Consumers are generally complainers, but contributors don't expect anything: they live by a standard that they want to leave something in this world which wasn't there when they entered. When we dedicate our lives to 'giving', we will get more out of life than if we had dedicated our lives to 'getting'.

10. Everyone needs to rely on someone stronger than them

Most of us can pinpoint someone as the 'cause' of our emotional and mental anguish and issues: father abandoned me, therefore I am this way; mother criticised me too much, therefore I am this way; my teacher humiliated me when I was five, therefore I am this way, etc. Pointing blame helps us avoid taking responsibility for ourselves and the role we play in perpetuating our unhelpful behaviours and attitudes. We cannot become reliant on the idea of a hero entering our lives and making everything better for us. We need to shift our own perspectives and outlooks on life; we need to un-wedge ourselves from our negative thought patterns and overcome our own negative perceptions of reality.

11. Events in my past are the root of my attitudes and behaviours today

Whilst our pasts do create our beliefs, it is not in control of our beliefs. Stories are just stories; we can't blame the past for our present: we are responsible for managing our present and what we choose to take away from our past. Beliefs aren't automatic: they're built up over time and they're usually supported by past 'evidence'. What people need to do, therefore, is focus on understanding the smaller components which make up the belief and choosing to reassemble the messages they take away from the past in order to reconstruct new, helpful beliefs. Things happened to you; you had no control over what happened to you, but you can control how you respond to these things.

12. My future outcomes will be the same as my past outcomes

The fear of the past repeating itself leads people to live sheltered lives within secure and familiar comfort zones. Whilst comfort zones may feel secure and stable, they don't give much more than that. You cannot grow within the sphere of your comfort zone. The past can never reflect the future, no matter how convincing the evidence is or how frequent the cycles of misfortune which seemingly repeat themselves are. We need to appreciate the present and commit to a life of living our best without allowing the shadows of the past to taint our present-day and potentially spoil our future.



ELLIS' FOURTEEN IRRATIONAL BELIEFS

13. I shouldn't have to feel sadness, discomfort or pain

No matter how positive our outlook on life is, we cannot expect to live a life free from sadness, pain, grief, stress and struggle even if you've already gone through a lot. Negative emotions are part of life, but being able to more accurately relate to yourself helps you manage and cope with these upsetting and disturbing life events. We aren't entitled to anything in life: entitlement is a self-consumed, irresponsible fantasy concept which doesn't have any basis in reality.

14. Someone somewhere should take responsibility for my life

Most people sit around waiting for their life to change, but empowerment comes from taking responsibility in life for yourself. We can go to therapists, life coaches, doctors, politicians, partners, parents and even children looking for external support, and help during difficult times, but we have to accept that we don't live in a Hollywood movie or a fairy tale. People can help you, comfort you and be there for you, but nobody is coming to save you: only you can save yourself.

REFLECTIVE EXERCISE

Take 5-10 minutes to reflect on each of the irrational beliefs that Ellis highlighted. and identify any that may be particularly relevant to you. Consider the following questions in relation to each of these rules:

1. In what areas or situations do you recognise any of these rules in your life?
2. Can you identify how these rules may have developed? Did you choose them or have their underlying beliefs developed from the influence of your family/friends as you were growing up?
3. How have these rules prevented you or limited you in terms of achieving the things you really want in life?
4. What changes can you start making today to start building these new beliefs into your life?

